

Photographs by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

MIRED IN LEGAL TROUBLES

- Azam Khan is an accused in 108 cases, many of them involving incidents of land-grabbing. There are 32 cases against his elder son Adeeb Azam, 46 against younger son Abdullah Azam while wife Tanjim Fatima faces 34 cases
- Azam surrendered in Rampur court on February 26, 2020, along with wife Tanjim and son Abdullah. Tanjim was released on bail after 10 months, Abdullah after 23 months while Azam got bail only on May 20, 2022
- Azam Khan contested the 2022 assembly poll as SP candidate from Rampur while still in Sitapur Jail. After winning the assembly seat, he resigned his MP seat from the Rampur constituency
- Has three cases of 'hate speech' from the 2019 LS poll campaign. The MP-MLA court of Rampur sentenced him to three years in hail on Oct. 27, 2022. Subsequently, he lost membership of the UP assembly
- Abdullah, a first-time MLA from the Swar assembly seat, had his 2017 election declared void after the court ruled that his birth certificate was forged
- Abdullah won from Swar Tanda in the 2022 assembly poll but was again disqualified after eight months. On February 13, 2023, he was convicted by the court
- Azam's elder son Adeeb Azam and daughter-in-law Sidra have stayed away from politics. Adeeb is in the construction business

> "NO POLITICAL FAMILY HAS HAD TO SUFFER THE KIND OF ATROCITIES THE YOGI REGIME HAS COMMITTED AGAINST AZAM KHAN"
>
> **–AKHILESH YADAV**
> *Ex-CM and SP president*

him losing his voting rights and the Rampur assembly seat. Son Abdullah Azam has met a similar fate. Within 48 hours of the decision of the Moradabad court, the Yogi regime had Azam's MLA status (from Rampur's Swar assembly seat) terminated. This is the first time in the past four decades that no one from Azam Khan's family is a member of Parliament or any house of the UP legislature.

Azam has had a long string of political successes going back to 1980 (see *Hustle & Bustle*). He and the late SP chief Mulayam Singh Yadav were very close and Azam was also a founding member of the party. Sushil Pandey, Muslim affairs expert and professor of history at Ambedkar University, Lucknow, says, "Mulayam needed a face who could act as a 'link' between his party and the Muslims. And from Saharanpur to Sonbhadra, every Muslim in UP knew Azam. It worked out well for both of them."

Things got a bit frosty after Mulayam's son Akhilesh Yadav became the chief minister CM in 2012. Azam was picked for the Speaker's job but he begged off saying he didn't have the patience needed to control events in the often unruly UP assembly (the legend goes that he told Mulayam, "I would not be able to tolerate people throwing paper balls at me. If they throw paper balls, I will throw paperweights"). Still, Azam was de facto No. 2 with important portfolios in the Akhilesh regime though relations between